We always try to surprise our opponents and push them to the backfoot. It worked.

Q. Was bringing in three fresh faces as the chief ministers of Rajasthan, MP and Chhattisgarh when you had stalwarts in all three states, also part of the same tactic?
We had to bring in a generational shift in leadership. We are not like the Congress party, where older incumbents would not let younger leaders in. The party has to grow. In 2009-10, when I became the general secretary in the central team, I was a state minister. Other new faces had also come. Many were surprised, but it was a conscious decision of the party organisation to bring us in. I have also decided to bring in younger leaders.

Q. Many were surprised by the choice of Bhajan Lal Sharma as Rajasthan CM. A first-time MLA who doesn't have administrative experience.
Shivraj*ji* had no administrative experience when he became CM, nor did Yogi*ji*, Khattar*ji*, Jairam*ji*, or Dhami*ji* when they became CMs. We all try to hand-hold them, try to present outstanding issues with clarity to them and help them in resolving those issues.

Q. Jyotiraditya Scindia, for example, could have been a choice in MP. Was it a conscious decision to appoint hardcore partymen as chief ministers?
It depends. If we have our own people ready, we go for it. If we are bringing in people from outside, they have to be given their due. We are not averse to taking in new people and are equally open to promote people with background in the party organisation. Scindia*ji* has a role to play at the Centre, and he has been given a very important portfolio.

Q. How is the party planning to use Shivraj and Vasundhara Raje, or have they retired?
They will get a lot of work according to their stature. They have so much experience...they are not retiring at all. They will have an important role to play in the 2024 election.

Q. While choosing the new CMs, caste considerations were evident. So the caste factor remains key for the BJP too?
Sabka Saath, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Prayas. We have taken everyone along. For us, everyone is equal. We believe in practical politics. We don't encourage caste-based politics. If Samajwadi Party comes to power, only one community will dominate; similarly with BSP and RJD. We are like a bouquet, everyone gets representation here. Earlier, people used to say that we were a 'Brahmin-Baniya party'; now, we represent everyone, take care of all communities. We don't believe in casteism.

Q. The Opposition, particularly some members of the INDIA formation, is rooting for a national caste census and Nitish Kumar pushed one through in Bihar. Where does the BJP stand on this?
We supported the survey in Bihar, but we haven't decided on a national caste census. The larger point is that the Opposition wants to do politics with it, they don't want the upliftment of every section of society. They are only interested in slogans, which helps them win OBC votes. They tried raising it in the recent polls, but it didn't work. What moral right does the Congress have when Jawaharlal Nehru kept sitting on the Kaka Kalelkar Commission report on the backward classes? What do they have to say about the Mandal Commission report (submitted in 1980), when Indira Gandhi and then Rajiv Gandhi were prime ministers? Lalu Prasad and Rabri Devi were CMs in Bihar for 15 years, what did they do for OBCs? Nitish*ji* has been there for so long, what has he done? They are not honest towards the cause. They look for vote bank politics. But under PM Modi's leadership, the BJP is giving representation to all backward communities and is taking care that the social fabric is not disturbed because of this.

> "WE HAVEN'T DECIDED ON A NATIONAL CASTE CENSUS. THE OPPOSITION WANTS TO DO POLITICS WITH IT. BUT THE BJP IS GIVING REPRESENTATION TO ALL BACKWARD COMMUNITIES. WE DON'T BELIEVE IN CASTEISM"

Q. What about the North-South political divide for the BJP? It had a reversal in Karnataka and expected to do better in Telangana, but didn't.
We don't believe in this North-South divide; it is a creation of the INDIA bloc. PM Modi has spoken innumerable times about the cultural ethos of the South—its leaders, literary figures, among other things. The BJP has 29 MPs in the South; the Congress has 27. Every political party has its own emergence story. We started from the Hindi heartland and gradually expanded; now, we will look for increasing expansion in the South. Our Telangana unit needs